

she acted in Marathi films, submitting to the humiliation of having her hairline cut back and her eyebrows trimmed. She talks of how she bought her first radio at 18 but returned it the next day when the first she heard on it that her idol K.L. Saigal had passed away. She tells Kabir of how she fell asleep in her father's lap at her first public performance at the age of nine in Sangli.

The hard struggle is accepted as philosophically as the tremendous fame. And yet there is the undeniable sorrow at the passing of an era. Of an age where music directors would collaborate with each other. How Naushad would record part of a song for Roshan and Roshan would record another for C. Ramchandra. How her guru, Ustad Aman Ali Khan Bhendibazaarwale, would make her eat an omelette wrapped in a roti before she sang, because she was so thin. How after a long day of recording, she, Jaikishen, Shankar, Hasrat Jaipuri and Shailendra would eat ice cream or trot off to Chowpatty to eat bhel puri.

It was a simpler, gentler, kinder time. Fans would just walk into Famous Studios at Tardeo upon hearing she was recording there. She could

"I would record two songs in the morning, two in the afternoon, two in the evening and two at night."

simply refuse Jawaharlal Nehru when he asked her to sing the famous *Aye mere watan ke logon* again for him at his Teen Murti home. Or even when cross with Raj Kapoor for first announcing and then not choosing her brother as music director, she would go to RK Studios, without addressing anyone, sing the title track of *Satyam Shivam Sundaram* in one take and walk off.

This is a woman, remember, who had no formal education. Who had the responsibility of taking care of a mother and four siblings. Who countered criticism with pure hard work—when Dilip Kumar once told her that Maharashtrians don't speak good Urdu, she quickly hired a maulana to teach her the language. And who spent her childhood, before her father went bankrupt, being a frightful bother to everyone, sitting inside a tyre so the girls could roll her down the street, climbing trees to pick guavas and mangoes and walking around the neighbourhood hitting everyone with a stick. A woman who was independent, feisty, and successful entirely on her own terms. A woman who never gave up or gave in. And through it all, kept her girlish gold payals on. ■

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. *Paths of Glory*
Jeffrey Archer, Macmillan
2. *The Associate*
John Grisham, Arrow
3. *The White Tiger*
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
4. *The 3 Mistakes of My Life*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
5. *Slumdog Millionaire*
Vikas Swarup, Black Swan

NON-FICTION

1. *Stay Hungry Stay Foolish*
Rashmi Bansal, CII, IIM-Ahmedabad
2. *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
3. *Outliers: The Story of Success*
Malcolm Gladwell, Allen Lane
4. *Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century*
Nandan Nilekani, Allen Lane
5. *The Audacity of Hope: Thoughts on Reclaiming the American Dream*
Barack Obama, Three Rivers Press/Canongate

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

8. *Sea of Poppies*
Amitav Ghosh, Penguin/Viking
9. *The Lost Flamingoes of Bombay*
Siddharth Dhanvant Shanghvi, Penguin/Viking
10. *Of Course I Love You... Till I Find Someone Better*
Durjoy Datta and Maanvi Ahuja, Srishti

NON-FICTION

7. *Leadership in the Era of Economic Uncertainty*
Ram Charan, TMH
8. *Spiritual Parenting*
Gopika Kapoor, Hay House
13. *7 Secrets from Hindu Calendar*
Devdutt Pattanaik, Westland

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

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